

The Claremont City Council held a meeting on Tuesday, June 22, 2021, in the Council Chambers of City Hall.

The meeting was called to order by Mayor Lovett at 6:30 p.m.

Members of the Council present:

Ward I Councilor Andrew O’Hearne
At-Large Councilor Dale Girard
At-Large Councilor Michael Demars
Assistant Mayor Allen Damren
Mayor Charlene Lovett
At-Large Councilor Debora Matteau
At-Large Councilor Nicholas Koloski
Ward II Councilor James Contois
Ward III Councilor Jonathan Stone

Also present:

Edward Morris, City Manager
Mary Walter, Finance Director

AGENDA CHANGES

None

CITIZEN’S FORUM

Patrick Adrian, Ward 1, talked about the optics of the “IT Cost Comparison between the City of Claremont and Sullivan County” which was submitted by Councilor Demars and included in tonight’s Council packet. He said that Councilor Demars is the owner of CCI Managed Services. His questions were: 1) Should Council decide to switch to an outside contractor, would Councilor Demars submit a bid? 2) If so, would the City consider that bid under the circumstances? And 3) Does Councilor Demars intend to recuse himself from such a vote, should one transpire?

Councilor Demars said his motive for making this suggestion was to create an environment to put more money into capital improvements. This is an area he has depth of knowledge because he does this type of work. He would make a public pledge that he would not make a contract with the City to provide IT services, and he would adhere to that for not less than 5 years, as long as he owns his company. His motive is to see Claremont be as efficient as it can be. He doesn’t see a reason to recuse himself as there is no conflict.

Mayor Lovett said at the June 5th meeting many items were brought up that will be future agenda items. A lot of ground work has to be done.

Councilor Koloski said at the end of Councilor Demars' document he stated that he is not interested in doing IT work for the City. Councilor Koloski said that he had also publicly brought up IT questions, so this is not the first time these types of questions have been brought up.

OLD BUSINESS (BUDGET)

Mayor Lovett said Council didn't have time to go over Revenues at the June 5th meeting. She recommended discussing projected Revenues and then go onto departments. 17 departments were tentatively approved (TA). All were unanimous except for Sanitation (Transfer Station), 8-1 vote to TA; and Police, 5-4 vote to TA.

There was discussion about ARPA (American Rescue Plan Act) and its impact on the budget. Mr. Morris said there is an approximate four-year timespan (2020-2023) to be able to show revenue loss.

When asked about shovel-ready projects, Mr. Morris said there are two more roofs on City Hall that need to be replaced, lead line replacement, water/sewer projects, and elevator issues.

Mr. Morris said that ARPA funds cannot be used directly to reduce the tax rate. 2020-2023 is the calculation period and then the money has to be spent by 2026.

Councilors asked clarifying questions and received answers regarding Revenues.

Councilors asked the City Manager to confirm what the projections are for Rooms & Meals tax.

Ms. Walter said the motor vehicle registrations are up. She suggested Motor Vehicle Fees could be increased by \$30,000 for a total of \$1,850,000. Council agreed.

Because of Sweetwater Hydro, Council agreed to increase Payment in Lieu of Taxes by \$4,000 for a total of \$112,111.

A motion was made by Assistant Mayor Damren and seconded by Councilor Matteau to tentatively approve gross Revenues of \$6,259,104.

Councilors moved on to discuss non-unanimous TA'd budgets.

Police Department

Councilors talked about the expense of staff versus funding for projects.

Councilors discussed using funds for projects instead of filling vacant positions.

Mr. Morris said it is poor budgeting to not fund vacant positions if you are trying to recruit to fill them. It sets a precedent that the Council is cutting/defunding the Police Department. He would like to leave the money in the payroll line and then look at the vacancies in January. He's projecting to have \$200,000 that could be moved at that time. It doesn't send a good message to not fund those positions in the budget.

Some Councilors said they felt snubbed because early on when they were asked what their priorities were for the budget, they said they wanted \$750,000 for paving and the City Manager came back with a \$650,000 proposal.

Regarding the effect on the COPS Grant, Police Chief Mark Chase said the application was clear that the funds were not meant to supplement a police officer. If the number of police officers go down, they could be asked to return the grant funds. As of 60 days ago, the Department was one person away from fully staffed, but that has changed. The Police Department needs all of its officers. They are actively recruiting to fill the vacant positions. To not fully fund the positions, sends an anti-police message. Without funding, it makes recruitment more difficult in a competitive environment.

There was a discussion about using part-time versus full-time officers. Chief Chase said the difference is training and liability. He does not support having part-time-certified officers do the same work as full-time-certified officer.

Council agreed that the Police budget would stand as tentatively approved by a vote of 5-4.

Councilor Stone said the majority of the Council wants to see paving of up to \$1 million. The number one complaint Councilors hear are the taxes and then roads. The City Manager needs to come up with that amount by tomorrow's Council meeting. Mr. Morris said he had presented an amount of \$985,000 which leaves \$15,000.

Planning and Development Department

Previously, when asked, Planning and Development Director Nancy Merrill had said she could use a part-time Zoning Administrator and a part-time Grant Administrator.

She said a 20-hour a week Zoning Administrator would cost somewhere around \$40,000 a year.

A majority of the Councilors were in favor of the City Manager finding the \$40,000 to support that position.

After some discussion, Ms. Merrill said her number one priority would be to have a half-time grant administrator. Council directed the City Manager to find the \$40,000 and to present that information tomorrow.

Council will vote on the Planning and Development Department's budget after the City Manager comes back with the recommendation.

Library

Council did not TA the Library budget because of the carpeting. Mr. Morris said tomorrow the City will ask to encumber \$20,000 for Library carpeting.

A motion was made by Councilor Koloski and seconded by Councilor O'Hearne to tentatively approve the Library budget of \$417,738.

Roll call vote:

O'Hearne - yes

Girard - yes

Demars - yes

Damren - yes

Matteau - yes

Koloski - yes

Contois - yes

Stone - yes

Lovett - yes

Motion carried 9-0.

Water Department

A motion was made by Councilor Matteau and seconded by Assistant Mayor Damren to tentatively approve the Water expenses & revenue of \$2,071,766.00.

Roll call vote:

O'Hearne - yes

Girard - yes

Demars - yes

Damren - yes

Matteau - yes

Koloski - yes

Contois - yes

Stone - yes

Lovett - yes

Motion carried 9-0.

Sewer Department

A motion was made by Councilor Matteau and seconded by Councilor O'Hearne to tentatively approve the Sewer budget of \$2,888,104.00.

Roll call vote:

O'Hearne - yes

Girard - yes
Demars - yes
Damren - yes
Matteau - yes
Koloski - yes
Contois - yes
Stone - yes
Lovett - yes
Motion carried 9-0.

Streets & Roads

Mayor Lovett said all are familiar with Council's desire to put more money into streets and roads. \$650,000 was budgeted, \$155,000 is to be transferred from other departments and Public Works has asked for \$65,000 to be encumbered, for a total of \$870,496.37 for FY 2021. She said this is the most amount to be dedicated to roads in the last 15 years. For FY 2022, the City Manager has been able to find \$985,600 for paving. Adding the paving grant for Cat Hole Road from the Sullivan County ATV Club (SCATV), that brought the total to over \$1 million.

Mr. Morris said this shows staff has been listening to the Council that roads are important and we are trying to find the funds without slashing City services. The City has multiple things that need to be done, for example, the City complex needs repairs. We are trying to fund infrastructure across the City. We have a pay study that recently came back; we have some underpaid staff. It is important to continue to move forward to fund infrastructure. It is really important to move through the strategic planning process and to look at the long-term plan for how we are going to make changes in our community.

When asked what the benchmark is for paving, Jeremy Clay, Assistant Public Works Director, said that \$1 million would be the right number with the staffing they have. Councilors agreed the \$38,000 grant for SCATV for paving Cat Hole Road should not be included in the \$1 million Paving amount and that the City Manager needs to find the additional \$15,000 to put the amount up to \$1 million.

Mr. Clay talked about the algorithm that is used to help determine when roads are to be worked on.

Mr. Clay talked about the sidewalk study that is being done by the Upper Valley Lake Sunapee Regional Planning Commission (RPC). The RPC will do an assessment and then look at them for ADA compliance. Next year, the proposed sidewalk budget will be significantly increased. Council would like to see the study as soon as it is available.

City Administration

Mr. Morris asked to leave the \$10,000 in Consulting for strategic planning. A majority of Councilors agreed to keep it in.

A motion was made by Councilor Matteau and seconded by Assistant Mayor Damren to tentatively approve the City Administration budget for \$914,589.00.

Roll call vote:

O’Hearne - no

Girard - yes

Demars - yes

Damren - yes

Matteau - yes

Koloski - yes

Contois - no

Stone - no

Lovett - yes

Motion carried 6-3.

CONSULTATION WITH LEGAL COUNSEL

None.

ADJOURNMENT

At 8:56 p.m., a motion was made by Councilor O’Hearne and seconded by Councilor Matteau to adjourn.

Roll call vote:

O’Hearne - yes

Girard - yes

Demars - yes

Damren - yes

Matteau - yes

Koloski - yes

Contois - yes

Stone - yes

Lovett - yes

Motion carried 9-0.

Respectfully Submitted,

Dorée M. Russell

Clerk to the Council